

Legionnaires on parade
French Foreign Legionnaires, bearing FAMAS assault rifles with bayonets attached, march along the Avenue des Champs Elysées, Paris, during the annual Bastille Day parade on 14 July 2006 *(above)*. The MAT 49 submachine-gun *(right)* was used by the Legion in the 1950s and '60s.

THE FRENCH FOREIGN LEGION is a unique mercenary force that traditionally provided a no-questions-asked refuge for rootless misfits. The most dramatic period in its extraordinary history came after World War II, when it was in the forefront of France's losing struggle to maintain a colonial empire. Its heroic defeat at Dien Bien Phu in 1954 is the stuff of military legend. Nevertheless, the Legion has outlived the French Empire to go forward into the 21st century as one of the world's most respected elite military formations.

The Foreign Legion was formed in 1831 as a way of evading a ban imposed on employing foreigners in the French Army proper. Based at Sidi-bel-Abbès in Algeria, it soon established a reputation for toughness, implacable discipline, and a readiness to take on recruits from any country without inquiring into their identity or personal history. The Legion attracted French and foreign volunteers – adventurers, refugees, the unemployed, and the homeless, men with something to prove and men whose lives had taken a wrong turn, and no doubt some individuals who should have been in jail. After World War I, potential recruits were fingerprinted to weed out escaped convicts and criminals on the run, but the Legion remained a haven for many with pasts they would prefer forgotten. After Germany's defeat in World War II, the Legion actively sought recruits in French-run prisoner-of-war camps, some of them Waffen SS soldiers who might otherwise have faced prosecution for war crimes. Even today, part of the Legion's appeal lies in the opportunity it presents to start a new life from scratch. Potential legionnaires who present themselves at Legion recruiting offices in France now have to show a valid passport, or some other identity document, and their background will be checked for security reasons. But it is still normal to enlist under a pseudonym and acceptable to lie about marital status – officially all legionnaires are unmarried.



NCO's arm badge
This diamond-shaped arm badge bears the Legion's "flaming grenade" insignia.

TRAINING AND SELECTION

The chief barrier to acceptance into the ranks of the Legion lies in the high level of physical and mental fitness required of recruits. They are subjected to a barrage of medical and psychological tests, as well as gruelling exercises before being accepted into the ranks. This is just as well, since the training regime is traditionally one of the most rigorous of any force in the world, including pitiless forced marches carrying full equipment. The discipline and the austerity of life as a legionnaire, added perhaps to unsuitable motives for joining in the first place, have made desertion a constant problem. Enlistment is initially for five years. A foreigner who re-enlists will qualify for French citizenship at the end of ten years' service; a full 15 years in the Legion earns the right to a pension. All NCOs are promoted from the ranks, but only 10 per cent of officers, the rest being provided by the French Army.



MAT 49 SUBMACHINE-GUN